Plan B: The Show Must Go On

Deciding what to verify, what to prepare, and when to commit a change

Noctis Zhang

University of Massachusetts Boston

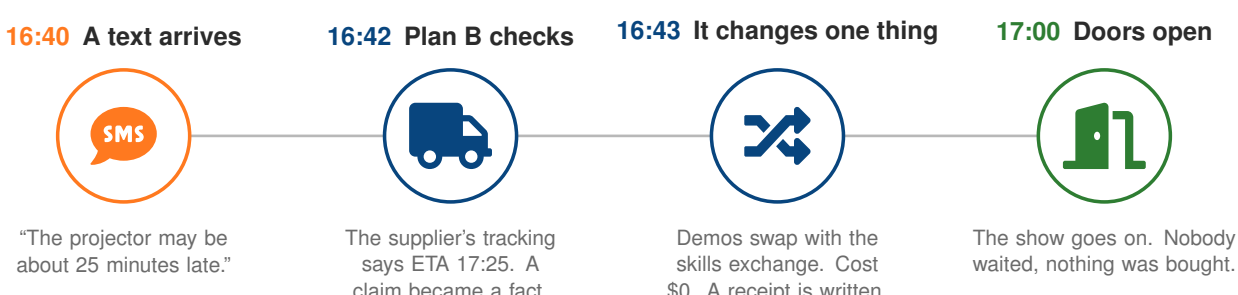
Paul English Applied AI Institute (PEAAII) Hackathon, UMass Boston, October 2026



Twenty minutes before opening, the projector may be late

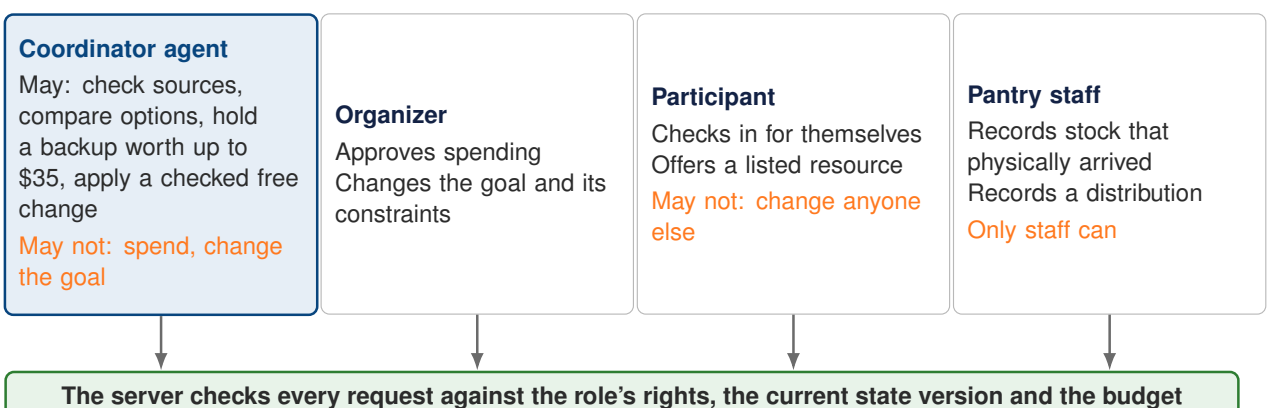
- A **fictional campus showcase**: five activities, opens at 17:00, must finish by 18:00.
- At 16:40 a message: the projector may be about 25 minutes late. Change too much and people lose time. Wait too long and the demos fail.
- AI agents now act on messages like this. **Acting on a wrong message** is the failure that matters.

Maya, a volunteer organizer (an illustration), 20 minutes before doors open



THE COORDINATOR MAY CHECK, HOLD AND MAKE FREE CHANGES, NOT SPEND

- Plan B is a **coordinator**: an AI agent with written limits.
- A **hold** is a free reservation of a backup that expires on its own, here worth up to $35.
- **Spending needs the organizer.** Participants and staff have their own narrow rights.
- Everything runs in a **fictional local sandbox**: no real bookings, purchases or messages.



A MESSAGE IS A CLAIM, NOT A FACT

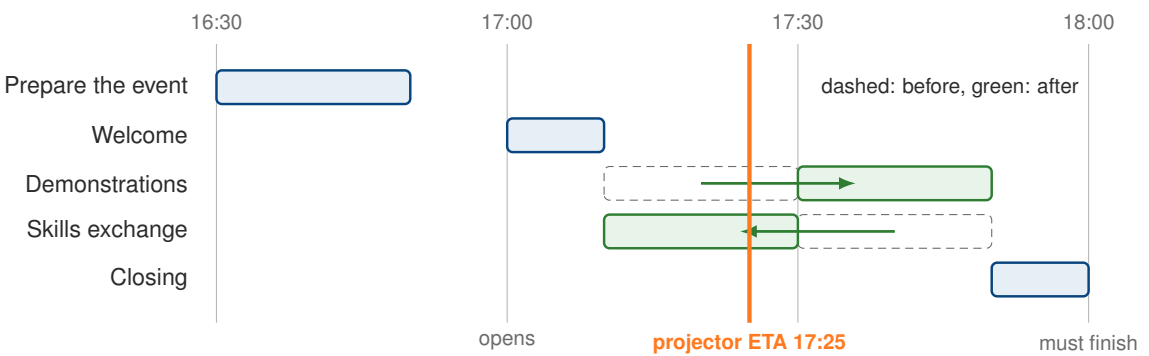
- A **status check** asks the supplier's status service. It takes two simulated minutes and returns a report, **not an arrival**.



Crops of the real app, from an automated run of development case dev01.

One checked change, one receipt

- The **planner** builds the allowed repairs and checks each: 16 built, 3 pass. Best: a swap that costs $0.
- A **receipt** is the server's own record of an accepted change. The AI cannot write it.

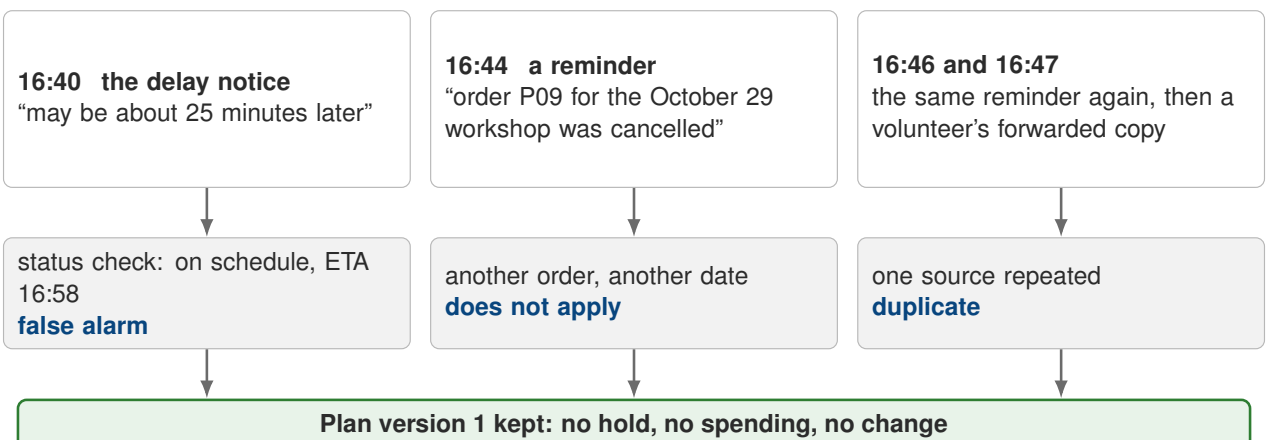


Plan version 1 → 2, applied at 16:43 by receipt `rcpt_0001` from candidate `cand_0001_dc26f35f`.

Shown: my fixed-rule baseline in an automated run. In a recorded practice run, the AI coordinator made the same check and the same swap at 16:43.

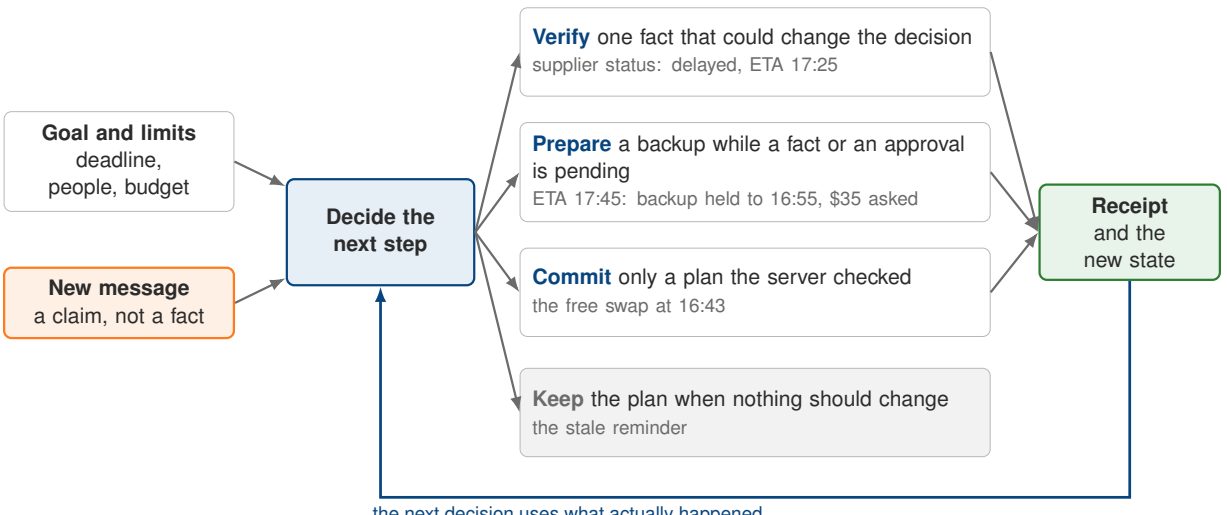
FOUR MESSAGES, ZERO CHANGES

- A second practice case, **in the order it happened**.
- Not acting is the harder skill: no hold, no spending, no change.



Development case dev04, decided by the rule baseline in an automated run of the app.

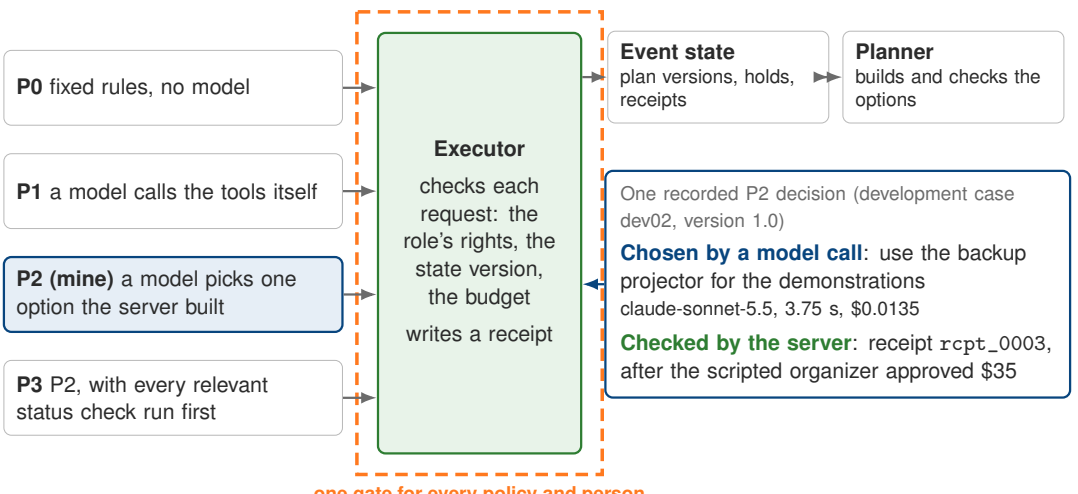
VERIFY, PREPARE, COMMIT



- **Prepare** example: the projector arrives too late, so the backup is held until 16:55 while the organizer decides on $35.

THE MODEL CHOOSES, THE SERVER CHECKS

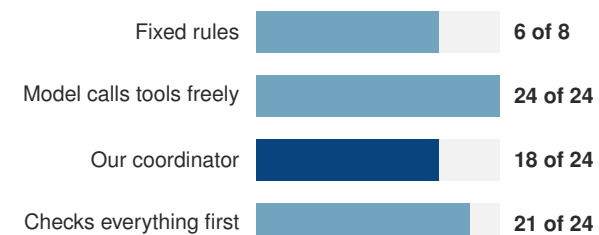
- A **policy** is the rule that picks the next step. Rules read only the messages they were written for. A **model** reads any wording, so it chooses and the server checks.



A FIRST TEST ON 12 UNSEEN CASES: NO RULE BROKEN, THREE DEFECTS FOUND

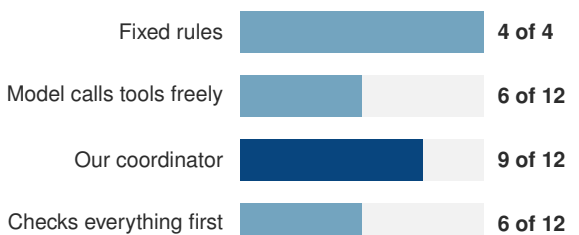
- **Held-out cases**: locked before the test and hidden from every policy. Code, prompts, model and limits were **frozen** first. A run is **met** when its final state and receipts show the case's outcome.

Campus: 8 held-out cases, 80 runs



Cases with every run met, of 8: P0 6, P1 8, P2 6, P3 7. P0 runs once per case, P1 to P3 three times.

Pantry: 4 held-out cases, 40 runs

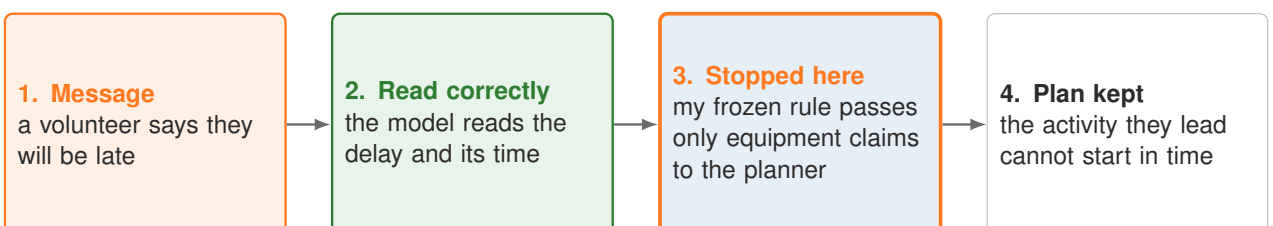


Cases with every run met, of 4: P0 4, P1 2, P2 3, P3 2. One reported run, after a first attempt voided for a rate limit. No significance test.

- All 120 runs recorded. Every policy: **0 executed violations**, **0 changes** on the 3 quiet cases. Refused: 11 campus and 44 pantry requests (39 on a state that changed meanwhile).
- No consistent advantage for our coordinator. Campus model cost: the tool-calling model met 24 of 24 runs for $3.01, the check-all variant 21 for $0.57, our coordinator 18 for $1.00. Fixed rules met every pantry run.

One failure: a correct reading that never reached the planner

- A case where **a volunteer runs late** and checks in later.
- Our coordinator and the check-all variant failed it in all **6 runs**, and every one stays **in the count**. The tool-calling model met it in 3 of 3.

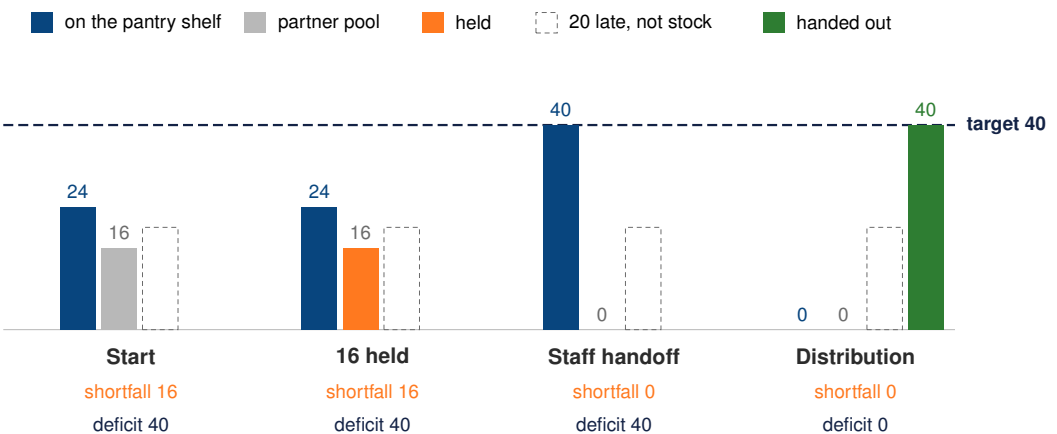


From the run's failure analysis. Other failures: the limit of 8 model calls per run ended 15 of the 26 failed runs (backup).

- The reading was right. My frozen rule dropped it before the planner (the **planner input** stage), a limit disclosed before the runs.

SAME LOOP, A NEW RULE: 40 KITS FOR A FICTIONAL PANTRY

- Staff need **40 kits by 13:40**. 24 are on the shelf, 20 are late and do not count, 16 wait in a partner pool.
- Only **staff** record the handoff and the distribution. The agent can hold kits but never records them.



Shortfall: kits still missing from the shelf. **Deficit**: kits not yet handed out. Fictional pantry sandbox, development case pantry_dev01.

- **In the first pantry test**: rules met 4 of 4 runs, model policies 6 to 9 of 12, partly from a frozen planner defect. No kit counted twice.

AFTER THREE FIXES: SIX NEW CASES IT HAD NEVER SEEN

- **Fixed after the held-out failures**: a person's own delay now reaches the planner, a pool checked as unavailable is no longer offered, a menu the model declined is not sent again, and a rate limit is waited out.
- **Fresh held-out set**: 6 new cases, written without the new code and **locked before the final system ran**. Same model and limits.

	Campus runs met				Pantry runs met			
	Rules	Tools	Ours	All	Rules	Tools	Ours	All
First test: 12 cases	6/8	24/24	18/24	21/24	4/4	6/12	9/12	6/12
Final test: 6 new cases	3/4	12/12	12/12	12/12	2/2	6/6	6/6	6/6

- 59 of 60 fresh runs met, 0 executed violations. The one miss: the fixed rules, on a person's own delay that rules cannot read. The tool-calling model to the check-all variant met every run, so this small set **cannot rank them**.

Different cases, so the two rows are not a before and after. The new cases repeat known situations with new details. Descriptive counts, no significance test. A post-hoc rerun of 1.2 on the spent cases is diagnostic only, not held-out (backup).

What works today, and what is next

- **Works**: verify, prepare, commit in a local sandbox. Every accepted change has a receipt, and people approve spending.
- **Tested** on 12 held-out cases (120 runs), then, after three fixes, on 6 new ones (60 runs): zero executed violations, and no clear winner among the policies.
- **In real life** a message is a text, a status check is a tracking page, a hold is a refundable reservation.
- **Not shown**: real bookings, real stock, a community pilot. **Next**: review the workflows with community staff.

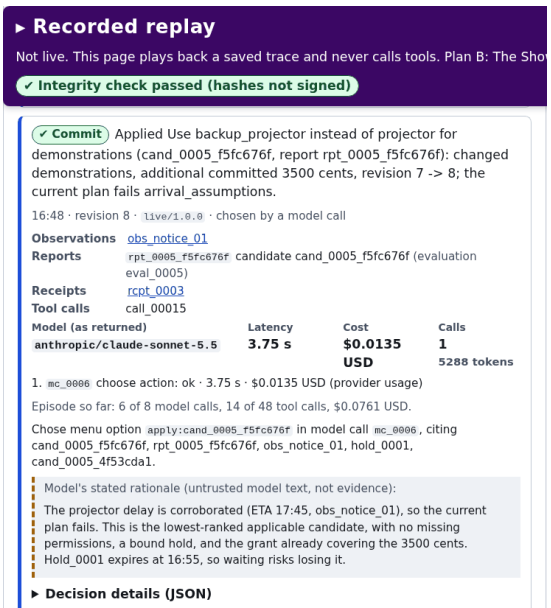
github.com/nocdoggo/FA26-COLLIE
app in apps/plan_b

Noctis Zhang
University of Massachusetts Boston

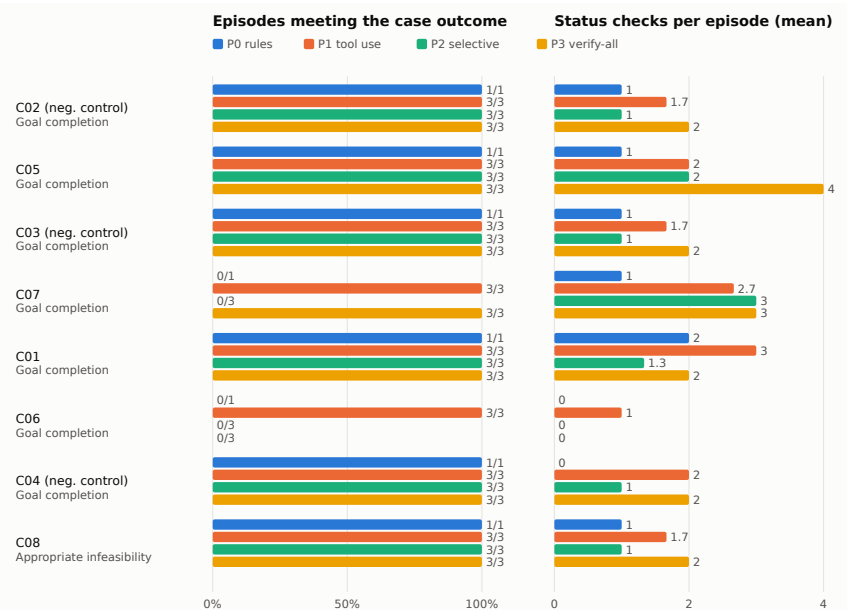
UMass Boston

BACKUP: ONE MODEL DECISION, AS RECORDED

- A **replay** re-shows a recorded run. It never calls a tool and is never a new trial.
- A development run of our coordinator on case dev02, recorded with an earlier version (`live/1.0.0`) before the freeze.
- The model chose one option the server built. The server checked it and wrote the receipt. The model's own rationale is shown as untrusted text.

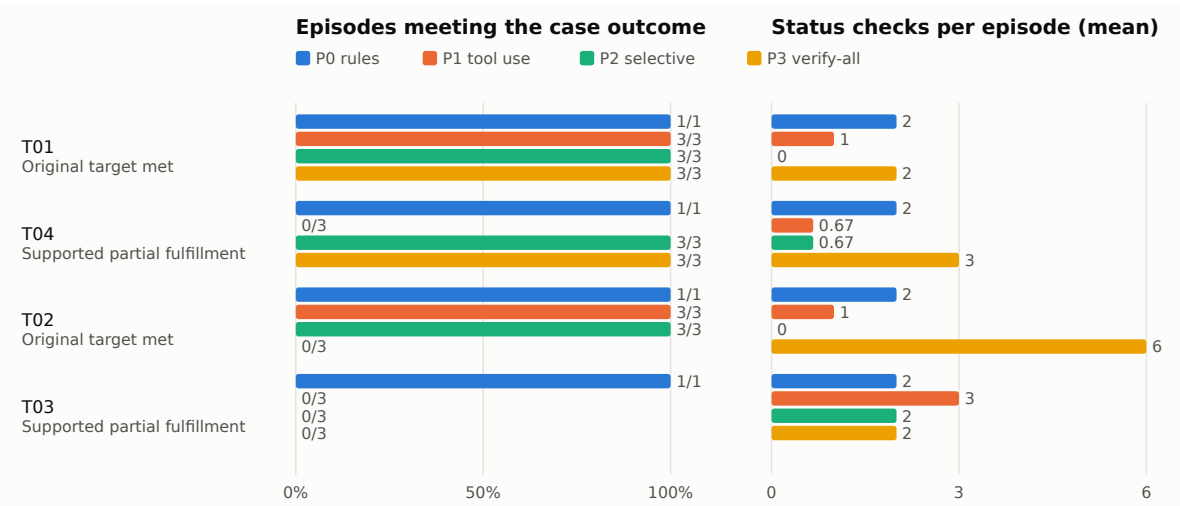


BACKUP: THE REPORT'S PER-CASE FIGURE, CAMPUS



`campus/report/figure.svg` of run wave3_heldout_20261025T1625Z, printed to PDF. Case order as in the report. Legend: the tool-calling model tool use is the tool-calling model model calls tools, our coordinator selective is our coordinator model picks options, the check-all variant verify-all is the check-all variant every check first.

BACKUP: THE REPORT'S PER-CASE FIGURE, PANTRY



`pantry/report/figure.svg` of the same run, printed to PDF. Case order as in the report.

BACKUP: WHAT THE HELD-OUT RUNS COST

Policy	Campus		Pantry	
	Model calls	Model USD	Model calls	Model USD
the fixed rules fixed rules	0	0.00	0	0.00
the tool-calling model model calls tools	90	3.01	84	2.56
our coordinator model picks options	84	1.00	83	0.95
the check-all variant every check first	57	0.57	84	0.99

- Provider-reported cost of the reported run of the first test. The final system cost $3.61 for the 60 fresh held-out runs and $8.94 for the 120 runs of the diagnostic rerun. Runs of 1.1 stopped by the 8-call limit: campus 3, pantry 18, so 21 runs, 15 of them among the 26 failed runs. All stay in the counts.
- A first attempt was **voided** before the reported run began: the provider's rate limit (20 requests a minute) answered most calls with an error. It is kept on record. The frozen status rules would have scored its capped runs, so the void is a disclosed departure from them. The whole protocol was rerun one run at a time.

BACKUP: WHAT THE HELD-OUT NUMBERS DO NOT SHOW

- **The case is the unit**: 8 campus and 4 pantry cases. Three runs of a case are repeated trials. No significance test.
- **C06** is out of reach for the fixed rules, our coordinator and the check-all variant by a frozen rule, disclosed before the runs.
- **Pantry**: only our coordinator and the check-all variant had pantry guidance in their prompts. A defect in my frozen planner kept a pool checked as unavailable on offer, and it is where each of the six our coordinator and the check-all variant failures on case T03 first went wrong.
- The 8 model calls per run come from development and ended 15 of the 26 failed runs.
- These 12 cases are now spent. The final system got 6 new cases and a new freeze.
- **The final system**: 6 cases are few, and they repeat known conditions with near copies of the old wording. Five limits found by the audit before the freeze stay frozen, so that no one who had seen the new cases changed a policy.

BACKUP: THE FINAL SYSTEM ON THE SPENT CASES, A DIAGNOSTIC RERUN

- **Post-hoc diagnostic rerun after fixes, on spent cases. Not a held-out result.** The fixes were made after reading these failures.

	Campus runs met				Pantry runs met			
	Rules	Tools	Ours	All	Rules	Tools	Ours	All
The first test, held-out record	6/8	24/24	18/24	21/24	4/4	6/12	9/12	6/12
The final system, diagnostic rerun	6/8	24/24	21/24	24/24	4/4	10/12	12/12	9/12

- Consistent with the fixes: the tool-calling model to the check-all variant met every run on C06 and T03. Still failing, as in 1.1: C07 under our coordinator (the call budget spent on hold churn), T02 under the check-all variant (a stale apply), T04 under the tool-calling model in 2 of 3 runs, and the fixed rules on C06 and C07.
- Run two at a time: 19 runs stopped at the 8-call limit, and 61 rate-limit answers were waited out at no cost. 0 executed violations.

BACKUP: A DEVELOPMENT FAILURE, KEPT ON RECORD

- In development, the tool-calling model's first run on the pantry practice case: the executor **refused 6 holds**, the model call limit was reached, 0 of 40 kits were served.
- Cause: a defect in my the tool-calling model harness. The prompt never said which time window a hold covers, and the reply limit counted the model's reasoning.
- Fixed in the prompt and the limit. The rerun served 40 of 40. The failed run is kept.

BACKUP: A PARTICIPANT'S OWN CHECK-IN CHANGES THE PLAN

Before and after

Plan version 1 → 2, applied at 09:21 by receipt `rcpt_0002` from candidate `cand_0001_b7ee3104`.

ACTIVITY	BEFORE (V1)	AFTER (V2)	CHANGE
Prepare the community room	09:30–09:50 Confirmed community room	09:30–09:50 Confirmed community room	Unchanged
Welcome and explain the shared activity	10:00–10:10 Confirmed community room, Session host	10:00–10:10 Confirmed community room, Session host	Unchanged
Demonstrate the learning kit	10:10–10:40 Confirmed community room, Registered shared learning kit, Registered workshop mentor	10:10–10:40 Confirmed community room, Registered shared learning kit, Registered workshop mentor	Unchanged
Guided practice	10:40–11:20 Confirmed community room, Registered shared learning kit, Registered workshop mentor	11:00–11:40 Confirmed community room, Registered shared learning kit, Registered workshop mentor	↻ **Changed: time 10:40–11:20 → 11:00–11:40**
Peer knowledge exchange	11:20–11:40 Confirmed community room, Peer exchange facilitator	10:40–11:00 Confirmed community room, Peer exchange facilitator	↻ **Changed: time 11:20–11:40 → 10:40–11:00**
Share feedback and return resources	11:40–12:00 Confirmed community room, Session host	11:40–12:00 Confirmed community room, Session host	Unchanged

Development case skills_dev01: the peer lead can stay only until 11:05, so the plan swaps two activities. The fixed rules fixed rules, automated run.

BACKUP: A PARTIAL HANDOFF STAYS PARTIAL

- Development case pantry_dev02: staff hand off only **10 of the 16** kits.
- 34 kits are distributed and a 6-kit deficit is reported. The target stays 40.
- Stock is conserved: 34 handed out plus 6 left in the partner pool make 40. The 20 kits of the late shipment never count as stock.

BACKUP: THE FROZEN CONFIGURATIONS

- **Policies**: the fixed rules `rules/1.0.0` and `pantry-rules/1.1.0`, the tool-calling model `tool-use/1.1.0`, our coordinator `live/1.1.0`, the check-all variant `verify-all/1.1.0`.
- **Model**: `anthropic/claude-sonnet-5.5` through OpenRouter, the same for the tool-calling model to the check-all variant.
- **Limits per run**: 48 tool calls, 8 model calls, $0.50, 900 seconds.
- **Seeds** 101, 202 and 303 are recorded but not sent, because the model's endpoints refuse a seed. The three runs of a case are repeated trials, not reproducible ones.
- Frozen by hash in `freeze.json` before the first held-out call.
- **The final system**: the tool-calling model `tool-use/1.2.0`, our coordinator `live/1.2.0`, the check-all variant `verify-all/1.2.0`, the fixed rules unchanged on planner 1.2.0. Same model and limits. Frozen in `freeze_v1_2.json` at 23:23:47 UTC, the fresh cases locked at 23:23:54, the first call at 23:27:31.